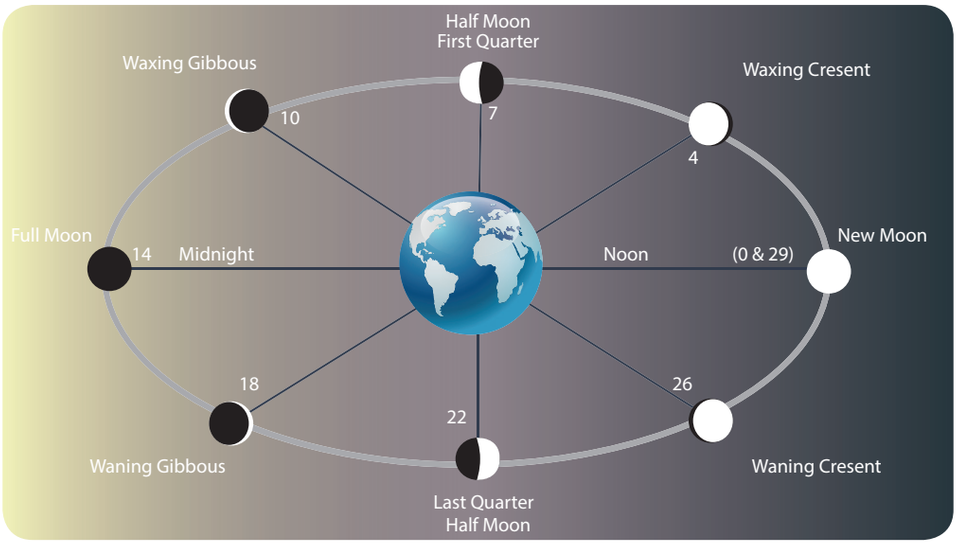


Figure 2.16 Phases of the Moon

Effects of the spherical shape of the earth

1) Variation in the amount of solar radiation received:

If the earth were a flat surface, oriented at right angle to the sun, all the places on the earth would have received the same amount of radiation. But the earth is spherical/ geoid. Hence the sunrays do not heat the higher latitudes of the earth as much as the tropics. On any given day only the places located at particular latitude receive vertical rays from the sun. As we move north or south of this location, the sun's rays strike at decreasing angles. The yearly fluctuations in the angle of the sun's rays and the length of the days change with the continual change of the earth's position in its orbit around the sun at an inclination of 66½ to the orbital plane.

2) Difference in the angle of the sun's rays striking different parts of the earth.

Away from the equator, the sun's rays strike the earth's surface at particular angle. The slanting rays are spread over a large area and do not heat with the same intensity as the direct rays. As we go pole wards, the rays spread over the regions beyond the Arctic and the Antarctic circles in an extremely slanting manner. This is how we get the various temperature zones.

Lower the degree of latitude; higher the temperature. Not only that, the rays striking at a low angle must travel through a greater thickness of the atmosphere than the rays striking at a higher angle. The rays striking at a lower angle are subject to greater depletion by reflection and absorption by the atmosphere.

Heat zones

The spherical shape of the earth along with its movement around the sun causes differences in the angles at which the sun's rays fall on the earth's surface. This causes a difference in the distribution of heat on the earth's surface.

As a result, the world has been divided into three distinct heat zones or temperature zones. They are the Torrid zone, Temperate zone and Frigid zone.

TN_Govt_Geography_XI_Std Unit_02.indd 41 2/3/2020 4:21:14 PM